

Writing a formal letter(II)

DISCUSS THE TOPIC

- Have you ever been to a restaurant/café where the service or food/drink was not satisfactory? What was wrong and what happened?
- Do you think people should complain in situations like this? Why/Why not?

SAMPLE WRITING

Read the rubric below and the sample letter on the next page. Have all the points been covered in the letter?

You recently went for lunch with a group of friends. However, you were not satisfied with many aspects of the café restaurant. Read the advertisement carefully and the notes you have made. Then, write a letter of complaint to the manager of the restaurant, covering the points in your notes and adding any relevant information.

Write a letter of between 120 and 180 words in an appropriate style. Do not write any addresses.

PINKY'S CAFÉ RESTAURANT



- Relax in air-conditioned comfort
- Special tasty lunch offers every day
- Vegetarian dishes
- Try our delicious Italian cakes
- Coffee from all over the world
- Reasonable prices

Book lunch for more than ten people and get a 10% discount at all our restaurants.

You'll find a Pinky's Café Restaurant somewhere near you.



Yuck!

Too spicy!

stale

outrageous!

wasn't working!

only two

staff unaware of this

Dear Sir / Madam,

I feel I must complain about the lunch we had at your restaurant on Thursday 17th December. Unfortunately, both the food and the service were not satisfactory.

To begin with, the dishes we ordered were not tasty because of heavy seasoning. There was so much salt and pepper on the food that it was impossible to eat the whole meal. Furthermore, your advertisement was misleading as there were only two vegetarian dishes on the menu.

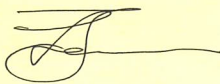
I must also point out that none of the desserts we ordered were fresh. In fact, the "delicious Italian cakes" were stale. As if this was not bad enough, the prices were far from reasonable and contrary to what was stated in your advertisement, we found everything outrageously priced.

To make matters worse, the air-conditioning was out of order. As a result, we were hot and extremely uncomfortable.

Finally, when we asked for the bill, we were surprised at the staff's ignorance of the 10% discount for group bookings. Again, this was something highlighted in your advertisement. We could have made a fuss about it, but we decided not to.

Considering all the above, I believe I am entitled to a partial refund. I am confident that this matter will receive your prompt attention. I look forward to hearing from you.

Yours faithfully,



James Kent

- 1 What language and tone does the writer use to make his complaints and show his feelings? Tick which of the following apply and find examples in the sample letter.**

The writer is :

- | | | |
|------------|--------------------------|-------|
| rude | ☐ | _____ |
| displeased | ☐ | _____ |
| uncertain | ☐ | _____ |
| emphatic | ☐ | _____ |
| apologetic | ☐ | _____ |
| firm | ☐ | _____ |
| friendly | ☐ | _____ |

- 2 In which part of the letter (Opening paragraph, Main part, Closing paragraph) does the writer:**

- | | |
|--|-------|
| a. make his complaints? | _____ |
| b. request action? | _____ |
| c. state the purpose of the letter? | _____ |
| d. mention when the incident took place? | _____ |
| e. refer to the advertisement and the notes? | _____ |

PLAN

This unit deals with another type of formal letter: a letter of complaint. Below is a plan of a letter of complaint, with questions to help you when planning one. Read the plan and compare it to the sample.

Greeting	• use an appropriate greeting	
Opening paragraph	use set phrases to: • state the purpose of your letter • give a general idea of your complaint (place, date etc.)	Why are you writing this letter? What are you complaining about? When did you buy the product or use the service?
Main part (2-3 paragraphs)	• state your complaint(s) clearly and logically, giving all the necessary details and facts	What exactly is the problem? How do you justify your complaint(s)? What did the advertisement/brochure etc. claim that was misleading? What is/was wrong with the product/service? Why aren't you satisfied?
Closing paragraph	use set phrases to: • state what action you would like the reader to take • end your letter	What would you like done about the matter? Do you want a refund or an exchange? When do you want action to be taken? Will you be taking any action?
Signing off	• use an appropriate signature ending. Sign underneath this and print your full name below your signature.	

GUIDE TO WRITING

- Plan your letter carefully and include all the complaints noted on the advertisement/brochure etc.
- Write the points in order of importance and, if possible, group similar points in the same paragraph.
- In most cases, letters of complaint have to be written in a formal style. Therefore, use formal language and be polite but firm.
- Avoid long detailed descriptions of events. Get straight to the point, making sure you explain your complaints clearly and that you justify them.
- Use linking words/phrases. Look at the table below for ideas.

listing points	firstly, to begin with, for a start, secondly, finally
providing additional information	furthermore, moreover, in addition, also, besides this, what is more
emphasising	in fact, apparently, obviously, to be honest, as a matter of fact, not only ... but also
expressing contrast	however, although, despite the fact that, in spite of, whereas, contrary to, in contrast
expressing result or consequence	therefore, so, as a result, for this reason, in this case, as a consequence
summarising	all in all, on the whole

- Use some of the following set phrases and expressions to emphasise what you are saying so as to draw the reader's attention to your complaint.

**Set phrases
for opening
paragraph**

I am writing to complain about/make a complaint about ...
I am writing to you regarding/in connection with/on account of ...
I regret that I am obliged to complain about ...
I feel I must complain about ...

It was completely different from....
I feel it is absolutely unacceptable....
I am dissatisfied with....
Unfortunately, it was nothing like what I expected.

**Expressions
for middle
paragraphs**

The problem is ...	To my amazement/surprise ...
I must mention/point out ...	Your advertisement/brochure was misleading in this
To make matters worse ...	respect.
As if that was not bad enough ...	In your advertisement/brochure you state otherwise.
I was shocked/surprised/ disappointed ...	You failed to mention that ... You led me to believe that ...

**Set phrases
for closing
paragraph**

Considering all the above, I believe I am entitled to a partial/full refund.
I demand a full refund/immediate action/a replacement.
I expect to be compensated/all expenses to be paid.
I would be grateful if you (would) deal with this matter immediately.
I would appreciate it if we could sort this matter out as soon as possible.
I feel sure/am confident that this matter will receive your prompt attention.
I hope that you will give this matter your attention.
I am afraid that if this matter is not dealt with immediately, I will ...
I hope to hear from you as soon as possible.
I look forward to hearing from you.
Thanking you in advance.

WRITING PRACTICE

- 1 a. Read the rubric below and the opening paragraph of the letter of complaint on the next page. The writer has used some expressions which are not suitable for this type of letter and has included some unnecessary details. Decide which points are not appropriate and cross them out.

You were president of a committee responsible for organising your school's end-of-year dance. The committee chose 'Delicious Catering Service' for the set-up and food. However, many problems occurred on the day. Read carefully the advertisement and the notes you have made.

Then write a letter of complaint to 'Delicious Catering Service', covering the points in your notes and adding any relevant information.

Write a letter of between 120 and 180 words in an appropriate style. Do not write any addresses.

hot-dogs
and
cheesepies
are not
gourmet

stopped
serving at
midnight

DELICIOUS CATERING SERVICE

Our experienced staff will give your special event that extra touch of class

We provide:

- ★ a choice of menus with delicious gourmet food
- ★ complete, easy set-up for marquee
- ★ unlimited drinks served by our staff
- ★ free cake

We cater for weddings, engagements and parties.

Our DJ will make your night a memorable one.

teenagers,
came late
and were
rude

took them
4 hours

didn't get

played
50's
music all
night

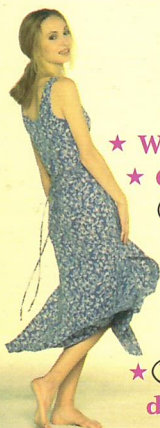
c. Write a suitable closing paragraph for the letter.

Yours faithfully,
Amanda Atkinson
 Amanda Atkinson

2 Read the rubric below and write a plan for the letter. Decide on the order in which you are going to make your complaints.

You saw this advertisement in a newspaper and decided to try the diet. However, one month later you are not satisfied with the results and have realised that the advertisement was misleading. Read the advertisement and the notes you have made. Then, write a letter of complaint to the company which advertised the diet, covering the points in your notes and adding any relevant information. Write a letter of between 120 and 180 words in an appropriate style. Do not write any addresses.

KIM'S WONDER DIET



Lose weight in three weeks!

★ We cook for you!

★ Our calorie controlled food is not only healthy, it's delicious too!

★ JOIN NOW and only pay for HALF your meals.

★ Meals delivered to your door.

For further information contact us on 5557890

gained 2 kilos

tasteless!

paid full price

cold/came late

answering machine always on

3 Task for homework.

Write the letter of complaint using the plan you made in exercise 2.